

CAN WE LEAVE THIS ARK WITH YOU?

Blue denotes PPT Slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

Red is where I am going to drill down

TEXT: 2 Samuel 6:1-11 (KJV) *“Again, David gathered together all the chosen men of Israel, thirty thousand. ² And David arose, and went with all the people that were with him from Baale of Judah, to bring up from thence the ark of God, whose name is called by the name of the LORD of hosts that dwelleth between the cherubims. ³ And they set the ark of God upon a new cart, and brought it out of the house of Abinadab that was in Gibeah: and Uzzah and Ahio, the sons of Abinadab, drave the new cart. ⁴ And they brought it out of the house of Abinadab which was at Gibeah, accompanying the ark of God: and Ahio went before the ark. ⁵ And David and*

all the house of Israel played before the LORD on all manner of instruments made of fir wood, even on harps, and on psalteries, and on timbrels, and on cornets, and on cymbals. ⁶ And when they came to Nachon's threshingfloor, Uzzah put forth his hand to the ark of God, and took hold of it; for the oxen shook it. ⁷ And the anger of the LORD was kindled against Uzzah; and God smote him there for his error; and there he died by the ark of God. ⁸ And David was displeased, because the LORD had made a breach upon Uzzah: and he called the name of the place Perezuzzah to this day. ⁹ And David was afraid of the LORD that day, and said, How shall the ark of the LORD come to me? ¹⁰ So David would not remove the ark of the LORD unto him into the city of David: but David carried it aside into the house of Obededom the Gittite. ¹¹ And the ark of the LORD continued in the house of Obededom the

Gittite three months: and the LORD blessed Obededom, and all his household.”

INTRO: The dwelling place of God, among the Israeli people, was within the Holy of Holies. Inside the Holy of Holies was an interesting piece of furniture called the Ark of the Covenant of the Lord.

Everywhere the Israelites went the Ark went first. Moses said, ***“If Your presence goes not with us, carry us not up hence.”***

The Ark was to be carried by the Priests and no one was to touch it. It was to be carried on the shoulders of the Priests utilizing staves that were fitted into the rings on each end of the Ark.

Everywhere the Ark traveled there was great victory. So much so that the Philistines recognized the supernatural power that surrounded the Ark and decided that if they

could capture it, they might become the beneficiaries of its blessings.

When Israel engaged in battle with the Philistines at Ebenezer and Aphek, they found themselves on the losing end of the conflict, and as messed up as they were, they called for the Ark.

They likely called for it because it had brought great victory in the past. Please allow me to point out an often overlooked fact. 1 Samuel 4:5 (KJV) *“And when the ark of the covenant of the LORD came into the camp, all Israel shouted with a great shout, so that the earth rang again.”*

Just because we are excited about the presence of God is no indication that we are ready for it. No amount of shouting can compensate for sin in the camp.

Just because there is a lot of noise in a church is no indication that everything is kosher.

This time the presence of the Ark did not convey victory, and Israel lost thirty thousand more men in the process. When the dust settled, the dead included Hophni and Phinehas, the evil sons of Eli who were playing a priestly role.

When Eli heard the news of his sons' death, his only concern was for the status of the Ark. When he heard of its loss, he passed out, fell backwards, and broke his neck in the fall.

The final victim on that infamous day was Phinehas' unnamed wife, who used her final breath to name her child Ichabod, meaning, ***“The glory of the Lord has departed.”***

The capture of the Ark of the Covenant by the Philistines was the fulfillment of prophecies spoken against the house of Eli.

What we allow at God's house, He will allow at our house!

The Philistines assumed the capture of the Ark would acquire the favor they had witnessed happening to the Israelites. Rather than favor, it brought curses on them.

The Ark was taken to Ashdod and was put in the temple of the Philistine god, Dagon. However, this synthetic god could not stand in the presence of the Ark.

In the seven months that it resided in the land of Philistia, the cities Ashdod, Gath, and Ekron experienced what was likely the bubonic plague and was overrun with rats.

After seven months of calamity, the

Philistines decided to see if the presence of the Ark was the culprit to their calamity. They had a brand new cart made and decided to have it pulled by never-before-harnessed cows that had young calves that they placed in a stall. They placed the Ark on the cart, and disgustingly, they also included replicas of the rats and tumors made of gold.

The Philistine experts in the supernatural made this a litmus test to determine whether the Ark was the problem or if their problems were just coincidental.

The test would be that if the cows head straight back to where the Ark came from, toward Beth-she-mesh, rather than going to where their calves were locked up, they would conclude this catastrophe was indeed a divine judgment. But if not, they would

know that God had nothing to do with it—it was just a coincidence.

God, in His wonderful response to queries, caused two un-driven cows that had never pulled a cart, who were mooing with hunger and leaving their calves behind, to walk straight from Ek-ron to Beth-she-mesh, a border town of Israel. Amazingly, the cows never left the road.

From Beth-she-mesh, the Ark was moved to Kir-jath-je-a-rim, where it stayed in the house Abinadab. (About 50 miles from the Tabernacle of Moses)

During this time, a priest from the line of Aaron did not attend the Ark, but an appointed priest, Eleazar, Abinadab's son, attended the Ark. (From the time the Ark was captured until it arrived in Jerusalem - 92 years)

Though not much is said about blessings or curses during this ninety-two year span, the fact is that during this time there was a widespread, fearful movement toward God.

While the Ark rested in the quiet, insignificant, obscure house of Abinadab:

- Samuel grew old...
- The people demanded a King...
- Saul was anointed king...
- Saul was defeated by the Philistines...
- David was anointed king...
- David reigned for seven years from Hebron...

All the while the Ark had been relegated to the backroom, I mean the house of Abinadab.

It was not until David finally conquered Jerusalem in the seventh year of his reign that he called for them to bring the ark to Jerusalem, the city of David.

In preparation for the trip from the house of Abinadab to Jerusalem, a new cart was constructed! The nation had witnessed the Philistines getting by with carrying the Ark on a cart and they thought they could do the same thing! **Since when does the church take its cues from the world?**

This is where the modern church is at practically, operationally, and theologically.

The church was never intended to adapt to the culture, it was intended to establish the culture.

Just because the world is doing it does not mean that we should!

They built a new cart and loaded the Ark onto it and a group of very capable men were assigned to attend it.

At the threshing floor of Nachon, the oxen stumbled and it appeared that the Ark would be tossed to the ground.

Abinadab's son Uzzah, who had been assigned to accompany the ark, put out his hand to steady it. To the shock and dismay of everyone involved, Uzzah was immediately struck dead.

Not even those whose duty it was to bear the ark were allowed to touch it. The history of improper conveyance of the Ark should have been enough to warn them of the danger that lurked nearby. On one occasion fifty thousand men had perished because they looked into the Ark.

Uzzah, in his zeal and hot, impatient eagerness, tried to steady the ark and as a result he was struck dead.

I believe this is a warning for all those in this day who are making attempts to steady the Ark. Here is what an attempt to steady the Ark looks like today:

- A failure to preach the whole counsel of God...
- A determination to engage people with no plan for real life change...
- A failure to introduce people to the Holiness of God...
- Believing that methods don't matter, motives are the important thing...
- Relegating the work of the Holy Spirit to a back room or beyond the property boundary... (This is done so that givers won't be offended)
- Pentecostal denominations being led into ecumenicalism at the expense of who they are...

Think about Uzzah's life. He was the son of Abinadab, in whose house the Ark had been stored for so many years. He had grown up

with the Ark in his house. He and his brother were charged with taking care of it as it made its way from their home to its new resting place in Jerusalem.

If we put ourselves in the place of Uzzah, it's easy to understand why he would do so. He was used to having it around – although he knew it was holy, it was also a familiar thing. It seemed perfectly natural to try to steady it, to keep it from falling.

Could it be that those of us in this room who have contended for Pentecost are just as guilty of a lack of respect for the presence of God as those who have relegated His presence to a back room or abandoned it altogether?

Being a champion of Pentecost is not enough! Believing in the supernatural is not adequate! We cannot allow for anything to become a substitute for the miracle working

power of God to be ushered back into His church!

Like Uzzah, we are often guilty of reaching out with our hands instead of reaching up with our hearts. We are guilty of trying to do spiritual work in the power of the flesh.

Could it be that we have become so enamored with defending His presence that in reality we are not experiencing His presence? What does His presence look like in a ministry?

- Souls saved...
- Believers filled...
- The bound delivered...
- The broken-hearted healed...
- The poor having the Gospel preached to them...

Quite frankly, David was terrified by the power of the Ark after it killed Uzzah and he suspended its journey for three months.

When we realize we have strayed from His presence and His power is no longer present, we should suspend everything and call a fast; declare a solemn assembly; and pray heaven down in our town.

When Uzzah died, David asked Obed-Edom if he could leave the Ark at his house. David wasn't just asking for a place to park the Ark, he was asking if Obed would do what needed to be done to attend the Ark. In effect he was saying "*Can we trust you with this Ark?*"

Against the backdrop of the death of Uzzah, wouldn't we be a little more than reluctant to have the Ark parked at our house? **There is no sign of hesitation on the part of Obed; he was not afraid to receive the Ark.**

Obed knew that a man with clean hands and a pure heart had nothing to fear from the presence of the Lord.

I believe the lack of hesitation on the part of Obed is because he already had his house in order. Before the Ark ever arrived, Obed feared and served the God of the Ark.

I ask every preacher and church member in this house, can we trust this Ark to you? Can we leave this Ark with you and trust you to treat it in a proper manner? Jude 1:3 (KJV)

“Beloved, when I gave all diligence to write unto you of the common salvation, it was needful for me to write unto you, and exhort you that ye should earnestly contend for the faith which was once delivered unto the saints.”

Remember, while the Ark was in the possession of the Philistines it brought curses; when it was in the custody of Abinadab it never seemed to bring a blessing or a curse; but when Obed-Edom hosted the Ark, it blessed him and his entire house!

The ark of God, that overthrew Dagon and smote Uzzah, was nothing but a fountain of blessing in the household of Obed-Edom.

What was the difference? The attitude and priority with which Obed-Edom cared for the Ark released the blessing from the storehouse of God. Can we leave this Ark with you? Will you give it priority?

In a three-month period the fortunes of Obed's house took a drastic turn:

- His house turned from poverty to prominence... (God is El Shaddai not El Get-by!)
- He became a man of honor rather than being despised... (Obed means slave – Every time someone called him by his name it was a painful reminder of who he was – The name Edom was assigned to him because he was an Edomite and a descendent of Esau - He was a “Gittite” this means that he was from the city of

Gath, the place of David's greatest enemy, Goliath.)

In a mere three months, Obed and his descendants became addicted to the presence of God.

Because he gave the Ark proper respect, Obed reversed the curse and found his destiny.

The day came that David returned to retrieve the Ark. Obed had a choice to make:

- Go back to his old way of life...
- Grieve the absence of the Ark...
- Pack up and follow the Ark...

When David came to take the Ark to Jerusalem, Obed and his house left all and followed the Ark!

This was an easy choice for Obed; he would give up his life and livelihood and follow the presence of God.

The proof of desire is pursuit! Can we leave this Ark with you?

In so doing, Obed-Edom established a legacy of generational blessings.

As a result:

- He became the keeper of the gate at the Temple...
- He became a singer and musician in the house of the Lord...
- He became the keeper of the treasury...
- He had more than 62 offspring that were all called blessed of God and served in the temple...

It doesn't matter what sort of background, education, or family history you have. When you have the good sense to give His

presence the honor it deserves, you are going to be blessed.

When David retrieved the Ark from Obed's house he did it the right way.

Who wants to bring back the Ark?